AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 10

The Government Capstone and Assurance Playbook

The whole portfolio, proven at once: every use registered, every decision owned, every record kept - so Northbridge can show, not just claim, that its AI is lawful, fair and stoppable.



GATES CP0-CP5 | 8 TEMPLATES | 20 GOLDEN RULES

Northbridge City and County is fictional. All figures in this volume are illustrative. Nothing here is legal advice: public law duties vary by jurisdiction and must be confirmed with qualified counsel.

START HERE

One portfolio, one proof - how to use this capstone

This volume closes the series. Volumes 1 to 9 each assured one service: strategy, the front door, benefits and casework, permitting, tax, procurement, emergency services, data and records, and workforce and trust. A council, an auditor or a resident does not experience nine services. They experience one government. The capstone therefore assures the portfolio as a single system.

Who should use it

- **Executives and elected members** signing the annual assurance statement.
- **Service owners** bringing a use to a gate or reporting an incident.
- **Assurance, audit and legal teams** testing evidence against this standard.

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EXECUTIVE LENS

Read pages 3, 7 and 31 before signing anything.

SERVICE LENS

Test one real resident journey, not nine demos.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If the evidence is not in the file, the assurance does not exist.

CAPSTONE THESIS

Assurance is the product the public actually receives

Each earlier volume ended with a service that worked. Working is not enough in government. A benefit prepared quickly but explained badly still fails. A permit checked correctly but recorded nowhere still fails on appeal. A warning drafted in seconds but signed by nobody still fails in an inquiry. The public receives the assurance around the output: the reason, the record, the remedy.

Core line: AI assures, officers answer. The system prepares the evidence - a named officer owns the decision, the record and the consequence.

Three shifts at capstone level

1. **From system to portfolio.** Risks interact: the same model, vendor or dataset may sit under five services. Assure the shared parts once, together.
2. **From launch to life.** Most harm arrives after go-live, through drift, a model update, a policy change or a quiet workaround. Assurance is continuous.
3. **From claim to file.** Every public claim about AI must point to evidence in the assurance file. No file entry, no claim.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund assurance as a permanent function, not a launch task.

SERVICE LENS

Judge the journey end to end, including the appeal.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish only what the file can prove.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Nine volumes, one Northbridge

Northbridge City and County serves an illustrative 412,000 residents. Across the series it built a front door, casework support, permitting checks, tax assistance, procurement drafting, an emergency communications centre, a records platform and a workforce programme. The capstone inherits all of it - including its gaps.

Volume	Northbridge use	Capstone inherits
1 Strategy	Portfolio and stop list	Risk tiers, funding line
2 Citizen Services	Grounded answers, routing	Front-door logs, language access
3 Benefits and Casework	Evidence, case summaries	Decision records, appeal data
4 Permitting	Standards as code	Versioned rules, officer reports
5 Tax	Pre-fill, explanations	Traceable assessments
6 Procurement	Drafting, comparison	Model-change and exit clauses
7 Emergency	Call support, dispatch aid	Surge and outage tests
8 Data and Records	APIs, retention	Lineage, disposal evidence
9 Workforce and Trust	Training, publication	Competence records, trust survey

Illustrative inventory. A real portfolio must be counted from its own register, not from a table in a playbook.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Count shared vendors and models across services.

SERVICE LENS

Follow the resident, not the org chart.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Carry known gaps into the capstone openly.

PORTFOLIO INVENTORY

Every use, one register, no shadow AI

Assurance starts with a complete count. The register is the single list of every AI use in production, pilot or procurement, including tools bought inside a larger system and staff use of general-purpose assistants on public data. If it touches a resident, a record or a decision, it is registered.

Each entry holds

- Use name, service, owner and accountable officer.
- Purpose, residents affected and decision it supports.
- Model, vendor, version and data sources, with lineage.
- Risk tier, stop-list check and gate status.
- Evaluation results, incidents and next review date.

Northbridge finding: its first full count found 23 uses against 14 expected - including two summarisation tools bundled in existing contracts. Neither was unsafe, but neither had an owner, an evaluation or a record. Unowned is unassured, however benign the tool looks.

Rule: **unregistered means unapproved.** Discovery is welcomed and logged; concealment is a conduct matter, not an IT matter.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Reconcile the register against spend and contracts quarterly.

SERVICE LENS

Give residents one front door, not nine disconnected ones.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the register in plain language.

One risk scale and one stop list for the whole portfolio

Tier	Meaning	Assurance
Tier 1 - Assist	Drafts, finds, summarises for staff	Owner check, sampling, log
Tier 2 - Support	Shapes a resident-facing answer or queue	Evaluation, fairness test, review date
Tier 3 - Shape decisions	Materially influences an officer decision	Full gate, independent assurance, publication

The consolidated stop list - AI never

- Decides eligibility, grants or refuses benefits or licences, or sets a tax assessment on disputed facts.
- Selects people for enforcement, inspection, fraud investigation or safeguarding action.
- Dispatches or downgrades an emergency response, identifies a suspect, or supports use of force.
- Awards or rejects a bid, excludes a supplier, or writes off public money.
- Disposes of a record, merges identities, or rewrites the official record.
- Issues a public warning, penalty or final determination without a named human signature.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Tier by effect on the resident, not by technology.

SERVICE LENS

Keep a staffed alternative for every resident-facing use.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The stop list binds vendors and pilots too.

GOVERNANCE

Who decides, who signs, who can stop it

Portfolio assurance needs three named roles for every Tier 2 and Tier 3 use. The **service owner** runs it. The **accountable officer** signs the gate and the annual statement. The **assurance lead**, independent of delivery, can pause a use pending review. Pause authority that needs a committee meeting is not pause authority.

Decision	Owner	Evidence
Register a use	Service owner	Template 1
Pass a gate	Accountable officer	Template 4
Pause or retire	Assurance lead / owner	Template 8
Annual statement	Chief executive and members	Scorecard, Template 7

> **Test it:** pick any live use at random and ask, in one call, who can stop it tonight. Northbridge runs this as a quarterly drill. A use nobody can stop out of hours is not assured, whatever its paperwork says.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Name people, not committees, against each use.

SERVICE LENS

Keep the non-AI route staffed during any pause.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every signature creates a record a resident may see.

ASSURANCE ARCHITECTURE

Three lines, one file



Assurance is a working room, not a binder: live register, live incidents, live evidence.

1. **First line - the service.** Owners evaluate, sample outputs, log incidents and keep decision records.
2. **Second line - assurance and risk.** An independent team sets standards, reviews gates, tests fairness and can pause a use.
3. **Third line - audit and external review.** Internal audit, external auditors, regulators and elected-member scrutiny test the file itself.

All three lines write to the same assurance file (page 9). Separate private evidence sets defeat the purpose: a reviewer must be able to follow one use from registration to retirement without asking anyone where things are kept.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Independence is structural: assurance does not report to delivery.

SERVICE LENS

Sample real cases with consent and safeguards.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Audit the file, then audit the service against it.

EVIDENCE

The assurance file: if it is not in the file, it did not happen

One file per use, indexed by Template 2. It holds the purpose and legal basis, the data and lineage, the rules traced to their source, evaluation and fairness results, the gate record, training and competence records, incidents and learning, supplier and model-change notices, and the retirement plan.

Record rules that survive an inquiry

- **Contemporaneous.** Write it when it happens. Reconstructed timelines are visible and damaging.
- **Attributed.** Every entry names who did, checked or signed it.
- **Versioned.** Model, prompt, rule and policy versions are kept, so a past decision can be replayed as it was made.
- **Retained lawfully.** Kept to the records schedule from Volume 8 - no longer, no shorter.

Design test: **could a reviewer, a court or a resident reconstruct this decision** - inputs, rule, version, human judgement - from the file alone? If not, the use is not ready.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund records work as assurance work, because it is.

SERVICE LENS

Residents get the reason in words they can act on.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Redact for disclosure; never rewrite for comfort.

PORTFOLIO EVALUATION

Evaluate the portfolio, not just each model

Per-system accuracy hides portfolio harm. The same error repeated across the front door, casework and tax becomes a pattern against one group of residents. Capstone evaluation therefore adds three portfolio tests to the per-use tests from earlier volumes.

Test	Question	Trigger
Consistency	Do services give the same resident the same answer?	Conflicting guidance found
Distribution	Who bears errors, waits and appeals, by group and place?	Gap beyond agreed threshold
Drift	Has performance moved since the gate, on live data?	Scheduled re-test, model change

Thresholds are set before results are seen, recorded in the gate record, and owned by the assurance lead. Moving a threshold after a failure, without a recorded reason and a re-test, is itself a reportable incident.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Report distribution, not only averages.

SERVICE LENS

Appeals are evaluation data, not a nuisance queue.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A failed re-test pauses promotion, then the use if uncorrected.

PUBLIC LAW

Law, rights and public duties at portfolio scale

Public bodies act under duties private firms do not carry: act within legal power, follow fair procedure, give reasons, avoid unlawful discrimination, protect data and confidentiality, and keep a proper record. AI does not dilute any of them. The officer who signs carries the duty the model cannot.

- **Reasons.** Every adverse or partial decision gives a specific, checkable reason and the route to challenge it.
- **Equality.** Portfolio distribution testing (page 10) is the evidence base for the equality duty - keep it current.
- **Data protection and confidentiality.** Tax, health-adjacent and safeguarding data carry heightened duties; access is role-based, logged and reviewed.
- **Freedom of information and disclosure.** Assume the file will be read. Write it so that reading it helps you.

> This page states principles, not law. Duties, exemptions and time limits differ by jurisdiction and service. Confirm each use with qualified legal advice and record that advice in the file.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Take legal review at design, not at launch week.

SERVICE LENS

A clear reason prevents more appeals than it causes.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Never let a vendor contract limit a statutory duty.

DATA, RECORDS AND SECURITY ASSURANCE

The shared foundations get assured once, together

Volume 8 set the data and records standard and the Security work across the library set the threat view. At capstone, assure the shared layer once: identity and access, APIs and interoperability, retention and disposal, logging, backup and recovery, and the AI-off fallback for every resident-facing service.

- Access review for every Tier 3 use, quarterly, with leavers removed same-day.
- Prompt-injection, leakage and extraction testing on every resident-facing system, repeated after each model change.
- Disposal evidenced, never assumed: certificates and sampled checks in the file.
- Outage test twice a year: AI off, service still safe, phones answered, paper route works.

The fallback is part of the service. **An AI service with no tested non-AI route is an outage waiting for a date.**

EXECUTIVE LENS

Assure shared platforms once; do not re-audit nine copies.

SERVICE LENS

Residents must never pay for an internal outage.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log access to sensitive records and actually read the logs.

SUPPLIER ASSURANCE

Suppliers are assured for the life of the contract, not at award

Volume 6 bought well. The capstone keeps bought systems honest: model-change notices tested against the contract, performance floors measured on Northbridge data, subcontractors and training-data terms re-checked annually, and exit rehearsed while the relationship is still friendly.

Check	Cadence	Failure response
Performance floor on local data	Quarterly	Remedy plan, then pause
Model or sub-processor change	Per notice	Re-test before acceptance
Data-use and training terms	Annual	Escalate to accountable officer
Exit and data return	Annual rehearsal	Do not renew unrehearsed

Concentration is a portfolio risk: if one vendor or one model underpins five services, its failure is a five-service failure. The register (page 5) must show that map, and the scorecard (page 19) must state it plainly.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Count concentration as a risk, not a discount.

SERVICE LENS

Exit is a rehearsed routine, not a contract clause.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

No resident data trains a general model. Ever.

WORKFORCE ASSURANCE

Competence is an assurance control

Volume 9 built the workforce programme. At capstone, competence becomes evidence: role-based training completed before access, supervised practice for decision-support tools, and refreshers triggered by incidents and model changes - not only by the calendar.

- No access to a Tier 3 tool without current training and a named supervisor route.
- Override is a skill: staff are trained, expected and thanked for challenging an output.
- Workarounds are signals. Staff routing around a tool are reporting a defect - log it as one.
- Agency and contractor staff meet the same standard before they touch a live case.

> **Northbridge lesson:** its highest override rate came from its most experienced caseworkers and predicted two of its three serious incidents. Teams that never override are not agreeing with the AI. They have stopped checking.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Protect override in performance reviews, explicitly.

SERVICE LENS

Train for the appeal and the outage, not only the happy path.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A tired, rushed checker is a failed control.

SERVICE ASSURANCE

Assure the journey a resident actually takes



One resident, one journey, several systems: assurance follows the person across all of them.

Systems pass their own tests while the journey fails between them: the front door promises a callback casework never sees, the permit portal asks for evidence the benefits team already holds. Journey assurance walks real (consented, safeguarded) cases across every handoff and scores the whole path: time, repetitions, contradictions, drop-outs and the quality of the final reason.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Walk journeys quarterly, including one that goes wrong.

SERVICE LENS

Tell residents once: reuse evidence lawfully, with consent.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Score the handoffs; that is where trust is lost.

WORKED EXAMPLE - END TO END

One Northbridge household, every control firing

A resident moves to Northbridge with a child, a disability and a new tenancy. In one month she touches the front door, benefits, a licence for a market stall, a home-adaptation permit and a council-tax account. Illustrative throughout - and deliberately ordinary. Capstone assurance is tested on ordinary cases at volume, not on showcase pilots.

1. **Front door** answers in her language, routes once, and records consent to reuse her evidence.
2. **Benefits** prepares the case from that evidence; an officer decides, signs and gives reasons she can appeal.
3. **Permitting** checks the adaptation against versioned standards; the planner judgement paragraph is written by the planner.
4. **Tax** pre-fills the account and explains the bill line by line, each figure traced to a fact and a rule.
5. **One record** follows her, access logged; one complaint route covers all five services.

When the tax explanation later contradicts the benefits letter, the consistency test (page 10) catches it, the incident log opens, and both letters are corrected with an apology. That correction - found, owned, published - is the capstone working.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Design for the household, not the transaction.

SERVICE LENS

One complaint route, however many systems.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A found contradiction, fixed openly, builds trust.

FAILURE AND LEARNING

Incidents are assured before they happen

Every portfolio will fail somewhere. Assurance is the speed and honesty of the response: detect, pause where needed, protect residents first, correct the record, tell affected people directly, then learn in the open.

Severity	Example	Response
S1	Wrong decisions at scale, data breach, unsafe guidance	Pause use, notify, correct, publish
S2	Group disparity, repeated wrong answers	Restrict use, re-test, notify affected
S3	Single wrong output, caught by checker	Log, fix, sample wider

- Residents affected by a wrong decision are told directly and offered review - they do not have to discover it.
- Corrections amend the record visibly; the original and the correction are both kept.
- Each S1 and S2 closes with a learning note in the file and a change to a control, a test or training.

Blame the control that let it through, **fix the control, and say so.** Blaming the model teaches nothing and protects no one.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Pre-agree pause authority and wording before launch.

SERVICE LENS

Proactive correction is cheaper than discovered error.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Share learning across services; the same failure travels.

TRANSPARENCY AND TRUST

Publish the portfolio, the performance and the failures



Northbridge from above: one city, one portfolio, one published account of how AI is used.

Northbridge publishes three things, on a stated cadence: the register in plain language, the portfolio scorecard (page 19), and a failures-and-fixes log drawn from the incident record. Publication is prepared from the assurance file using Template 6, so what is published and what was assured can never quietly diverge.

Residents are told, at the point of use, when AI is involved, what it does and does not do, and how to reach a human. That notice is tested with residents, in the languages the front door supports, and its comprehension is part of the scorecard.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Publish failures with fixes, on schedule, not on exposure.

SERVICE LENS

Say AI is involved before the resident has to ask.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Trust is measured by behaviour: appeals, overrides, reuse.

MEASUREMENT

The portfolio scorecard: one page the members actually read

Measure	Northbridge illustration	Direction
Uses registered / discovered unregistered	23 / 0 in last quarter	Zero unregistered
Decisions with complete reasons	96 percent sampled	100 percent
Appeal rate and appeal success rate	Tracked by service and group	Success rate falling
Error distribution gap, widest group	Stated in points, with action	Narrowing
Incidents S1/S2 and time to correct	Count and median days	Faster correction
Residents reaching a human on request	98 percent within target time	100 percent

Illustrative format only. Publish definitions with the figures, keep definitions stable across periods, and restate openly when a definition changes. A scorecard whose definitions move is marketing, not measurement.

EXECUTIVE LENS

One page, same definitions, every quarter.

SERVICE LENS

Pair every average with its distribution.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Report the worst number, not only the best.

ECONOMICS

Whole-life value, and the courage to retire

Capstone economics counts the whole life: build or buy, assurance, training, records, evaluation, incident correction, exit and the staffed non-AI route. A use that saves handling time but doubles appeals has not saved money. A use that cannot fund its own assurance cannot afford to run.

- Unit cost per correct, sustained outcome - not per transaction processed.
- Appeal, correction and complaint costs charged back to the use that caused them.
- Annual retire-or-renew review for every use: value proven, risk current, owner named - or it retires.
- Decommissioning uses Template 8: data returned or destroyed with evidence, records retained to schedule, residents told, register updated.

Retirement is a success outcome. **Keeping a weak use alive to avoid admitting the pilot failed is the most expensive option on the table.**

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund assurance inside each use, visibly.

SERVICE LENS

Charge failure costs to the use, honestly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Renewal is a decision, never a default.

GATES CP0-CP5

The capstone gates: from inventory to annual sign-off

CP0 Count - Register every use; reconcile against spend, contracts and staff practice.

CP1 Classify - Tier every use; confirm the stop list holds; name owner and accountable officer.

CP2 Evidence - Build the assurance file for each Tier 2 and Tier 3 use to the Template 2 index.

CP3 Test - Portfolio tests: consistency, distribution, drift, security, outage and journey walks.

CP4 and CP5 follow on the next pages. No gate is passed on a presentation: each is passed on evidence in the file, recorded with Template 4.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence matters: do not test a portfolio you have not counted.

SERVICE LENS

Assurance effort follows tier, not enthusiasm.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Gate records are public-record documents; write them that way.

GATES CP4-CP5

Remediate, then sign - in that order

CP4 Remediate - Fix findings, retire or pause what cannot be fixed, re-test, and record what remains open with an owner and a date.

CP5 Sign and Publish - Accountable officers sign per use; the chief executive and members sign the portfolio statement; register, scorecard and failures log are published.

Open findings at sign-off

Signing with open findings is allowed. Signing without disclosing them is not. The statement lists each material open finding, its risk, its owner and its closure date. An assurance statement with no open findings, in a portfolio of this size, should prompt a reviewer to look harder, not relax.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sign what is true, list what is open.

SERVICE LENS

Open findings get dates and owners, not adjectives.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publication is part of the gate, not an afterthought.

ROADMAP

A 12-month capstone roadmap Northbridge can actually run

Quarter	Work	Gate
Q1	Full count, register reconciliation, tiering, stop-list audit	CP0-CP1
Q2	Assurance files for Tier 3, then Tier 2; pause authority drill	CP2
Q3	Portfolio tests, journey walks, outage test, supplier re-checks	CP3
Q4	Remediation, retire-or-renew reviews, statement and publication	CP4-CP5

Then the cycle repeats annually, with quarterly scorecards between statements. New uses join through the volume gates from earlier in the series and enter the register at once - the capstone is a standing discipline, not a one-off project with an end date.

> **Resourcing note:** Northbridge runs this with a small central assurance team plus named time in each service. Budget the service time explicitly; assurance done in spare time is assurance not done.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Annual cycle, quarterly rhythm, continuous register.

SERVICE LENS

New uses enter the system, not a side door.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep the team small, senior and independent.

TEMPLATES 1-2 OF 8

Templates that carry the capstone

Template 1 - Portfolio Register Entry

Fields	Use name; service; owner; accountable officer; purpose; residents affected; decision supported; model, vendor and version; data sources; risk tier; stop-list check; gate status; evaluation date; incidents; next review; human alternative.
Rule	No entry, no use. Update on any model, vendor, data or purpose change - the same week.

Template 2 - Assurance File Index

Sections	1 Purpose and legal basis. 2 Data and lineage. 3 Rules and sources. 4 Evaluation and fairness. 5 Gate records. 6 Training and competence. 7 Incidents and learning. 8 Supplier and model changes. 9 Publication. 10 Retirement plan.
Rule	One file per use, this index, no exceptions. A missing section is recorded as missing, with an owner and date.

Copy the tables, keep the field names, and store completed templates in the assurance file for the use.

Declaring the limits, recording the gate

Template 3 - Stop-List Compliance Declaration

Fields	Use; each stop-list item marked Not applicable / Designed out / Controlled, with evidence link; officer signature; date; next review.
Rule	Signed per use, refreshed on any change. Designed out beats controlled: remove the capability rather than policing it.

Template 4 - Gate Review Record (CP0-CP5)

Fields	Gate; use or portfolio scope; evidence reviewed; thresholds and results; findings; conditions; decision (pass / pass with conditions / pause); signatures; review date.
Rule	Thresholds recorded before results. Conditions carry owners and dates and stay visible until closed and re-tested.

TEMPLATES 5-6 OF 8

Learning in the open, publishing from the file

Template 5 - Incident and Learning Log

Fields	Date detected; severity; use; residents affected and how identified; action and pause decision; corrections made; notifications sent; root control failure; change made; learning shared with which services.
Rule	Affected residents are identified from records, not from who complains. No incident closes without a control change or a recorded reason none is needed.

Template 6 - Transparency Publication Pack

Contents	Plain-language register extract; scorecard with definitions; failures-and-fixes summary; point-of-use AI notice; sign-off page with preparer, checker and file references for every published figure.
Rule	Every published figure traces to the assurance file. If it cannot be traced, it is not published.

TEMPLATES 7-8 OF 8

Scoring the portfolio, retiring with evidence

Template 7 - Portfolio Scorecard

Fields	Period; measures from page 19 with definitions; result; prior period; distribution breakdown; worst result and action; preparer and checker signatures; file references.
Rule	Definitions fixed across periods. A changed definition is flagged on the face of the scorecard and the prior period is restated.

Template 8 - Decommission and Exit Assurance Form

Fields	Use; reason for retirement; residents and open cases affected; data returned or destroyed, with evidence; records retained and schedule; vendor confirmation; register update; resident notice; officer signature.
Rule	No use is retired until open cases have a human owner and the data evidence is in the file. Switching off is the last step, not the first.

WORKED EXAMPLE - REVIEW

Northbridge capstone review: what the file actually showed

Illustrative review, first annual cycle. Of 23 registered uses, 4 were Tier 3, 11 Tier 2 and 8 Tier 1. The review passed CP0 and CP1 cleanly, then CP2 found the real work: three Tier 2 files lacked fairness results, one Tier 3 use had no rehearsed exit, and two services were giving different answers to the same housing question.

- One bundled summarisation tool was paused for six weeks until its file was complete - service continued on the staffed manual route.
- The housing contradiction was corrected, affected residents were written to, and the consistency test became quarterly.
- Two low-value Tier 1 uses were retired at CP4 rather than assured: cheaper, and honest.

The statement was signed with five open findings listed. That list, published, drew more confidence from members and auditors than a clean sheet would have - because it matched what staff and residents already knew.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Pause one use well rather than wave all through badly.

SERVICE LENS

Retire weak uses at review; do not assure them forever.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the open list. It is the credibility.

ANTI-PATTERNS

Capstone failure modes to refuse

Anti-pattern	Why it fails
Assurance theatre: binders written for the audit, unused in service	Reviewers sample live cases; theatre collapses on first contact
Register by self-declaration only	Misses bundled and shadow uses - reconcile against spend and contracts
Averages without distribution	Hides exactly the group-level harm public duties exist to prevent
Thresholds moved after results	Converts evaluation into decoration; log it as an incident
Vendor assurance accepted unread	The duty stays with the public body, not the supplier
Clean statements with no open findings	Signals a review that did not look, in any real portfolio

Refusal test: **if a practice would embarrass the service when read aloud** in a public meeting from the file, stop doing it now, while stopping is still cheap.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sample live work, never only documents.

SERVICE LENS

Reconcile, distribute, disclose - every cycle.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Your duty cannot be outsourced, only your tooling can.

ASSURANCE CHECKLIST

Capstone assurance checklist

Before sign-off, confirm each line from evidence

1. Register reconciled against spend, contracts and practice this quarter.
2. Every use tiered, owned and named to an accountable officer.
3. Stop-list declarations current for every Tier 2 and Tier 3 use.
4. Assurance files complete to the Template 2 index, gaps recorded.
5. Consistency, distribution and drift tests run, thresholds pre-set.
6. Security and leakage tests current; outage test passed this half-year.
7. Supplier performance, change and exit checks current; concentration mapped.
8. Training current for all Tier 3 users; override rates reviewed.
9. Incidents corrected proactively; learning notes filed and shared.
10. Scorecard prepared from the file, definitions stable, worst results shown.
11. Open findings listed with owners and dates on the statement.
12. Register, scorecard and failures log published on schedule.

Any line that cannot be confirmed is an open finding. Record it; do not work around it.

GOLDEN RULES

20 golden rules for government AI assurance

1. Unregistered means unapproved.
2. AI assures, officers answer.
3. If it is not in the file, it did not happen.
4. Tier by effect on the resident, not by technology.
5. The stop list binds pilots and vendors too.
6. Reasons a resident can act on, every time.
7. Report distribution, never only averages.
8. Set thresholds before you see results.
9. Appeals are evaluation data.
10. Pause authority must work tonight, not next committee.
11. A tested non-AI route is part of every service.
12. Correct proactively; do not wait to be found out.
13. No resident data trains a general model.
14. Exit is rehearsed while relations are friendly.
15. Override is a skill - train it, protect it, thank it.
16. Publish the register, the scorecard and the failures.
17. Charge failure costs to the use that caused them.
18. Renewal is a decision, never a default.
19. Sign what is true and list what is open.
20. Assurance is continuous, or it is theatre.

SIGN-OFF AND SERIES CLOSE

The annual statement, and what Northbridge signs

> **Assurance statement (form):** We confirm that every AI use in this portfolio is registered and tiered, that the stop list holds, that each material use has a complete assurance file or a listed open finding with an owner and date, that affected residents have been corrected and told where this cycle found error, and that the register, scorecard and failures log published with this statement were prepared from that file. Signed: Chief Executive. Signed: Accountable Officers. Date. Next statement due.

This closes the AI in Government and Public Services series: ten volumes, from Strategy to this Capstone. The argument across all ten is one sentence long. Government may use AI to prepare, check, find and draft - and a named officer decides, signs, records and answers, every time, in a file the public is entitled to trust because it is entitled to read it.

AI in Government and Public Services - Volume 10 of 10. Northbridge City and County is fictional and all figures are illustrative. Confirm legal duties for your jurisdiction with qualified counsel. Series index: 1 Strategy. 2 Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors. 3 Benefits, Licensing and Casework. 4 Permitting, Planning and Land Use. 5 Tax, Revenue and Compliance. 6 Procurement and Supplier AI. 7 Emergency Services and Public Safety. 8 Data, Records and Interoperability. 9 Workforce, Ethics and Public Trust. 10 Government Capstone and Assurance.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sign annually, assure continuously.

SERVICE LENS

The series ends; the register does not.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Trust is the record, kept honestly, in public.